

SAMARKAND FILE

Fate kills in silence

Written by

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Based on  
The segment from my novella

ICARUS'S FALL

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1 EXT. RAVATKHODZHA BORDER CHECKPOINT -DAY

Ray stands at the border checkpoint, clutching a tattered Uzbek passport.

He is 30ish, wearing a dark army green field jacket, shouldering a heavy outdoor backpack.

Ahead, two lanes: CITIZENS and FOREIGNERS.

Ray steps into the citizens lane, but a standing officer blocks his way.

Ray hands over his passport. The officer checks.

BORDER OFFICER  
Name?

RAY  
Rustam Iskandarov.

The officer flips through the passport, reveals a hint of doubt, especially for his Eastern Asian features.

His broken left arm-the empty sleeve still shows visible traces of dried blood.

BORDER OFFICER  
What happened to your arm?

RAY  
I need a doctor, immediately.

2 EXT. UZBEKISTAN BORDERLANDS -DAY

When Ray finally emerges from the end of border checkpoint.

A vast panorama of Uzbekistan scenery unfolds-barren, snow-covered mountains, long stretches of desert steppe, and a shimmering narrow river cutting through the emptiness.

3 INT. BORDER AREA CLINIC - DAY

An old Sharp 32-inch LCD TV is playing a soccer game.

AMIR (40s), a local GP, sits on a couch in his yard, eating Oshi. His two kids play Lanka nearby.

KID  
Daddy, look!

Amir spots a strange pale-faced man staggering towards them.  
It's Ray.

Ray almost collapses straight onto the couch.

A fistful of five-dollar bills scatters onto the greasy ground.

RAY  
Morphine... amphetamines... any  
painkillers!

Amir investigates his body, discovering his mangled left arm  
bleeding.

A yellow rubber tourniquet tightly binds the cut on his arm.

The wound, smashed by a blunt object, had been treated in haste,  
but is now infected and in poor condition.

AMIR  
I can't do it here. It's too serious  
for my place. You need a real  
hospital.

He administers some intravenous antibiotics and gives Ray  
painkillers.

He notices the patient is pale and sweating heavily.

RAY  
I can't go to a hospital. I need to go  
to Ishchan.

Ray snatches all the pills from Amir's hand and stuffs them into  
his mouth.

AMIR  
Ishchan... Yes, bigger place. More  
help for you.

RAY  
Drive me there.

AMIR  
I have no car.

Ray retrieves a wad of cash, and tucks it into Amir's pocket.

RAY  
Rent a car, now.

Ray leans on the couch, looking outside and scanning something  
in the yard.

RAY (CONT'D)  
Give me your food. All of it.

Ray devours Amir's Oshi with a dirty fork while watching the TV.  
Two kids stand in the corner, their eyes fixed on this patient.

RAY (CONT'D)  
Do you have CNN?

AMIR  
No.

Ray finishes the food on the plate and lies down onto the couch,  
murmuring to Amir.

RAY  
I take a nap. Wake me up once you  
get a car.

4

EXT. SUBURB OF ZAAMIN - DAY

TITLE CARD: Two days ago, Zaamin, 300 miles east of Samarkand.

A flimsy iron gate is unlocked, revealing a modest walled  
compound with a typical Central Asian two-story house.

GAITMAN (38), pale-haired, walks out of the front door, behind  
three kids and his WIFE, a slim woman in her thirties.

Gaitman carries a medium-sized backpack and a plastic bag of  
snacks.

His eldest son lugs a heavy khaki canvas pouch, striding through  
the courtyard towards a used Toyota Tundra.

When everything is loaded into the truck, Gaitman kisses his  
wife.

GAITMAN  
Two weeks, wait for me to return.

His wife remains silent.

Her arms rest gently on the children's shoulders, as if to keep  
them from rushing out of the yard.

Gaitman starts the car. As he drives out, he glances at the  
yellow canvas pouch.

He pulls it open by the drawstring—inside: five magazines, a  
rifle, and an Glock 17.

5 EXT. ROAD -DAY

Gaitman drives along a long, narrow road heading southwest.  
He pulls into a gas station and tells the attendant.

GAITMAN  
Fill it up.

6 INT. GAS STATION MINI-MART - CONTINUOUS

He steps into the mini-mart, orders a Turk qahva, and sits down at the table by the glass window, gazing outside.

From his viewpoint, the attendant refuels the truck, standing close to the passenger seat, but soon turns away. All is fine.

A beat.

He turns off the cellphone and removes the SIM card from the phone.

He holds it over an electric hot plate until it curls and blackens.

He breaks the phone and walks out of the shop, drops both pieces into the trash bin, gets into the car and drives away.

7 INT. HOTEL PAMIR -DAY

Room 210, a suite. Gaitman rearranges the room the room.

He lies down on the bed and realizes the bed is directly facing the door.

He pushes the bed in the corner, away from the door, then draws all the curtains shut.

He hears a distant gunshot.

He lifts a corner of the curtain and peers outside, a quick check, trying to see where the gunfire came from.

A knock at the door. A hotel maid delivers a parcel. Gaitman opens it, a new Vodafone SIM card and a MiFi.

He links the MiFi to his computer and sits down, waiting. A new message box pops up in his Outlook.

MESSAGE BOX  
Update?

GAITMAN (TEXT)  
Arrived, need a brief.

Four seconds later, a mail arrives.

A file folder called Samarkand File.

He opens it. these file shows a target: a man in his thirties, East Asian features, wearing a flight suit. A name appears under the photo: Sheng Ray.

Gaitman studies the face, long enough to memorize it.

8 EXT. MOUTH OF THE VALLEY -DAY

Dawn.

At the valley entrance by the river, a group of local hunters sit around by the campfire, smoking, drinking black tea.

The game lies nearby, some still alive. A ram, tied with a rope, grazes on the grass.

The hunters curse the weather, the government and everything else.

They notice a Toyota Tundra approaching. A man gets out of the car.

Gaitman sits down by the campfire, resting his khaki canvas pouch on the ground.

He wears dark green hunting gear and passes around naswar to everyone.

HUNTERS  
We want Philip Morris...

A burst of cheerful laughter.

GAITMAN  
How much for this live ram?

He points at the ram, which stops grazing and stares at Gaitman.

9 EXT. MOUNTAIN SLOPE - DAY

The ram is tied to a tree.

Gaitman draws a small circle on the tree trunk with chalk.

He takes his rifle, then walks two hundred meters away. Raising the gun, he aims carefully.

A shot.

The ram jerks violently, struggling to break free, but the rope holds it fast.

The gunshot echoes through the valley.

Gaitman walks back, checks the alignment of the bullet hole and the small circle, then adjusts the sight.

With a knife, he cuts into the rope, stopping just short of severing it.

He returns to his previous position. The ram struggles desperately to break free.

After repeated attempts, it finally escapes. It bolts down the hillside.

A gunshot.

The ram collapses, struck in the head.

10

EXT. RIVER SHORE - DUSK

The ram's head lies at the edge of the river. The flowing water washes away the blood.

Gaitman skillfully works with his knife, slicing into the fat beneath the skin, then peeling away the hide.

His trousers and chest are stained with blood.

He stops and steps to the river, bends down to wash his hands and knife.

A bicycle bell rings.

Turning back, he sees several local high school girls riding along the path by the river, approaching him.

They stop when they notice Gaitman and the decapitated ram.

A girl in front is thin, her hair dry and brittle, dressed in a wool cardigan.

She looks at Gaitman.

Gaitman looks back at her.

Finally, the girl climbs onto her bicycle and rides away with others, fading into the dusk horizon.

11 EXT. ISHCHAN TOWN - DAY

Downtown of Ishchan, a prosperous town in the barren borderland, 150 kilometers from Samarkand.

A battered Chevrolet Matiz pulls into the alley beside the marketplace.

A man gets out, he's weak.

He struggles to hoist a massive backpack onto his shoulders. A missing left arm makes every moment awkward.

Sun is shining.

Gaitman hides in the bell tower of a nearby mosque, watching Ray through a single-barrel telescope in the shadow.

He confirms that this is his target.

Ray takes a plastic bag filled with colorful prescription vials from Amir's hand.

A business card left behind.

AMIR

Look for doctor Akhmedova, Malika  
Akhmedova. She can help you. Good  
Luck, Mr. Iskandarov.

Amir's two kids sit in the rear seat, waving to Ray until the Matiz disappears in the dust of the crowded street.

Ray walks slowly along the secluded alleyway, scanning the advertisements one by one.

Old Hajji hotel.

Here it is.

12 INT. OLD HAJJI HOTEL - DAY

Aziz, son of Old Hajji, feeds coal into a blackened stove.

A pot of water boils on top, sending faint smoke drifting through the room.

This is the Old Hajji Inn, a timeworn Central Asian compound.

He notices a figure entering the foyer. He stares at Ray standing before him like a ghost.

Ray's eyes are swollen, right eye bloodshot.

His lips are ulcerated, a dark bruise spreads beneath his cheekbone.

Aziz takes out a small metal tin ointment and hands it to Ray.

AZIZ

The glare from the snow is strong.  
Many people don't know. My cousin lost  
his right eye.

RAY

You know me?

AZIZ

My father told me a man would come  
to look for him. It's you.

13 INT. OLD HAJJI'S LIVING ROOM - DAY

Ray sits on the wicker bench in the corner.

Another stove stands there, but no kettle rests upon it.

Its firebox is open, flames visible inside.

Ray pulls a SOG Seal Blade from his backpack and slips it into his boot.

Then he presses his feet together, watching the silhouette shift outside the window.

CUT TO

Old Hajji sits down by the stove, inspects Ray's fake passport. He wipes his nose and smears it on the stove's outer wall.

Ray watches in disgust as the sticky mucus sizzles and dries.

OLD HAJJI

Bad, Really bad.

He throws the passport into the stove.

Flames rise.

Ray's right hand quickly grips Old Hajji's shoulder.

OLD HAJJI (CONT'D)  
It's safer without a passport than  
have a fake one.

RAY  
Why?

OLD HAJJI  
You've added a new crime. Better burn  
it.

Ray's grip slowly loosens.

He leans back in the bench again, eyes fixed on Old Hajji.

OLD HAJJI (CONT'D)  
I'll do my job. You don't need to  
worry about that.

RAY  
How long?

Old Hajji wipes his nose and fumbles the stove again.

His hand gets burned, he curses.

OLD HAJJI  
It's already in motion. Even after it  
is made, they will bring it from  
Samarkand in three days. The road is  
not always safe.

Ray remains silent.

Old Hajji stretches his hand to Ray.

OLD HAJJI (CONT'D)  
I need the money first. Ten thousand  
bucks.

Ray pulls an envelope from the inside pocket of his jacket.

Still warm.

RAY  
As agreed. I get the passport, I pay  
another ten thousand.

Old Hajji snatches the money and stuffs it into his sheepskin  
vest.

OLD HAJJI  
Don't go anywhere. Don't look for me.  
When the time comes, I'll find you.

14 INT. RAY'S ROOM - DAY

Ray stands in the shower chamber.

He doesn't turn on the tap.

Instead, he dips a towel into soapy water and wipes down his torso.

His left arm is still bound with a yellow elastic band, though clearly treated further.

Across his waist and abdomen, numerous puncture marks from injections of adrenaline and morphine.

He sleeps naked on the bed, wrapped in an electric blanket. Shivering from the cold, it takes him a long while to settle.

In his hand, he holds the business card, then reaches to a nightstand for an alarm, two hours.

He shuts his eyes.

15 INT. STREET EATERY - DAY

A small chaikhana, opposite to Old Hajji hotel.

Gaitman scrutinizes a local map, drinking black coffee.

He finishes looking at it, walks over to the shopkeeper, pays, and returns two packets of sugar.

At the doorway, he stands watching the entrance of Old Hajji's inn.

A Lada pulls up at the inn's entrance. Old Hajji stands at the doorway.

A man steps out of the car without turning off the engine.

He hands the keys directly to Old Hajji.

The man is tall—one meter eighty-five—with a heavy build.

Botir.

Old Hajji whispers a few words to him, then slips two dollar bills from his pocket and passes them to Botir.

Taking the keys, Hajji climbs into the car and drives away.

Botir doesn't go anywhere.

He just sits at the inn's doorway, seeming to wait for someone.

Soon, Ray appears at the door, approaching an idle mototsikl taxi outside.

After exchanging a glance, he walks away and mounts the mototsikl toward the far side of the alley.

16

EXT. ROAD - DAY

Gaitman pulls over his Toyota Tundra to the roadside, far from Ishchan.

All around lies open wilderness. To the south rises a hill.

He unfolds the map—at the spot where he parks—seventy kilometers from Samarkand, forty from Ishchan—roughly one third of the way.

He steers off the road, stopping in the dirt of the desert plain.

He searches for four to five large stones by the roadside, then laboriously moves them to the middle of the road.

He slings his khaki canvas pouch over his shoulder and climbs in the shadow of the southern hill, stopping behind a boulder.

He raises his rifle and waits.

It's mid-afternoon, three o'clock.

The sun casts heavy shadows across the south hill.

Through the scope lens, the landscape is silent, no sound, no moving object—only drifting clouds.

A car comes.

It stops abruptly. The center cross mark in the scope follows the driver, who curses as he gets out to inspect.

Gaitman doesn't pull the trigger.

He forms a silent "Bang" with his lips.

He packs away the rifle and marks a red circle on the map, then he descends the hill.

17 INT. AKHMEDOVA CLINIC - DUSK

Malika expels the air from the syringe.

Her eyes fixed on a frail boy before her. The boy's skin is dark. His thin frame conveys his fear.

Malika places a hand on his shoulder, giving it a gentle pat. From the drawer she takes a piece of chocolate and offers it to him.

The boy turns to look at his mother, whose eyes are full of embarrassment.

Malika nods and tucks the chocolate into his open hand.

MALIKA

Clench your fist. Look at me.

The needle delivers the medicine. The boy squeezes his eyes shut in pain, waiting until it is over.

BOY

Can I keep this chocolate?

A nurse approaches, whispering.

NURSE

Doctor, someone says he must see you, right now.

MALIKA

Appointment?

NURSE

No.

MALIKA

Tell him to wait.

NURSE

His left arm, it's broken.

Malika lifts her head in silence.

CUT TO:

INT. OPERATING ROOM - DAY

A small chamber in the corner of clinic, it's a crude operating room where half the fluorescent tubes are dead.

Ray lies on the table.

Malika bends over, loosening the yellow tourniquet, which instantly triggers his extreme pain.

As she loosens the rubber tourniquet, a thick stream of pus flows out, mixed with blood, dripping into a metal tray on the floor.

Ray says nothing.

His shirt is soaked with cold sweat.

Malika inspects the wound.

It's already festering, oozing green-yellow discharge.

She draws a deep breath.

MALIKA

Who treated this before.

RAY

Forget it.

MALIKA

You need to go to Samarkand, not here.

RAY

I can't go to Samarkand. I stay here.

MALIKA

That's impossible. You'll die here.

A tip of a SOG Seal blade against Malika's chin.

RAY

Do it.

A beat.

Malika stares at the blade. The blade catches the cold light overhead, casting a sharp reflection across her face.

They lock eyes.

Malika notices Ray's hand trembling.

MALIKA

It's not about money.

Malika falls silent. She begins to work on Ray's wound. Ray lies there, watching her quietly.

He retrieves the blade.

RAY  
Give me the best. I'll pay  
everything.

18 INT. HOTEL PAMIR - NIGHT

Gaitman walks through the kitchen with his khaki canvas pouch.

The torso of the ram he killed is lying on the butcher block, separated, being cut by Azamat, who is both the innkeeper and cook.

Part of the carcass is already simmering in a big pot.

AZAMAT  
Dear sir, I don't know how to thank  
you. You know, there's hardly any game  
to hunt this season... I don't know  
how much this should cost?

GAITMAN  
Forget it.

AZAMAT  
When will you eat, sir? Iâ€™ll  
prepare it right away.

GAITMAN  
I don't eat anything.

He strides past the pot, glimpses at the boiled water and the layer of fat foaming on top.

CUT TO:

19 INT. GAITMAN'S ROOM - NIGHT

He empties the cabinet, pulling out all the clutter. He shoves the rifle deep into the back. Then Gaitman puts the bedding, pillows, and towels back over it. Only the scope stays in his hand.

He checks. Nothing shows.

He makes a black coffee and sits on the windowsill. Dust falls outside. The town sinks into darkness.

Ray returns on a mototsikl. Gaitman lifts the scope. Ray reaches the doorway, exchanges a glance with the burly man, Botir, and steps into the hotel.

A light comes on in Ray's room. He eats on the bed, ravenously.  
 Gaitman checks his watch, finishing the last sip of his coffee.  
 He walks to the door, closes it, and hangs the "Do Not Disturb" sign on the handle.

20

INT. MAA & SONS CAFÉ - NIGHT

A dilapidated, faded "Maa & Sons Café" sign glows in the night sky, lit by a few fluorescent tubes.

Below it, smaller letters: Snacks, Cold Drinks, Internet, Public Phone.

Lola places pomegranates, apricots, grapes, and apples into a plastic basket and washes them with lightly salted water.

She cuts them into pieces. The juicer starts.

Lola strains blended chunks through gauze and pours the liquid into a large glass container.

She adds a little sugar, honey and lemon juice, along with ice cubes.

Lola finishes. She sits idle in a chair, staring outside.

Across the street, a man approaches.

She still remembers him.

CUT TO:

The public phone, hanging from a rusted aluminum pole, rings.

It is picked up at once.

GAITMAN

Have you seen my wife?

REAL ESTATE AGENT

I went to the station to meet her. She was two hours late. Two whole hours.

GAITMAN

Is she with the children?

AGENT

Yes, she's with the two kids. I took them to see the house you mentioned. They liked it. Did I give you the price? I think I said it.

GAITMAN  
Say it again.

Gaitman listens quietly, then hangs up.

He pauses, then walks to Lola.

GAITMAN (CONT'D)  
I need the internet. One hour.

He sees the girl, Lola.

LOLA  
3000 som. (turns back) Brother! Start  
the Internet.

Lola's eyes linger on Gaitman, who sits down in front of a  
computer, checking something

He wears a gray shirt, with a coarse wool coat over it, looking  
warm.

He sits for a moment, then rises, and walks toward her.

GAITMAN  
A cup of juice, no sugar.

Lola pauses. A beat.

LOLA  
All our juices have sugar.

GAITMAN  
Ok, forget it.

Gaitman sits back to his seat. Lola watches him as he moves.

The hem of his trousers is frayed.

His shoes are dirty. Gray socks show.

Lola's gaze returns to her high school textbook on her desk,  
lingering for a long time.

She hears a voice.

GAITMAN (CONT'D)  
Check, please.

Three thousand som are placed on the table. Lola looks up.

Gaitman turns and walks away.

She quickly glances back at her father, who is in the small inner room making Samsa by the fire. Mother is beside her younger brother, guiding him with his homework.

She turns back.

LOLA

Wait, sir.

21

EXT. RIVER SHORE - NIGHT

Gaitman stands by the river. Foam rises lightly at his feet. The ram's head from yesterday is gone.

At the horizon, only the last trace of light. He lifts his eyes: across the river, a fox searches for food on the barren riverbank.

It sees him.

Gaitman holds the fox's gaze until it limps away into the dark.

He waits.

From the tall bushes nearby comes a rustling, then the whisper of cloth against cloth.

Lola steps out. She looks at him, then lowers her head.

GAITMAN

We should go back.

She nods, takes the bicycle by the roadside. They walk along the river bank toward town. In silence.

Lola breaks the silence.

LOLA

Do you know why I'm called Lola? It's not my real name.

GAITMAN

I don't know.

LOLA

Because of a famous model, Zilola Nuralieva. Z-I-L-O-L-A. I like her. One day I'll go to Japan, China, and America.

Gaitman says nothing. They keep walking. Near the edge of the town—

LOLA (CONT'D)  
Goodbye and see you tomorrow!

GAITMAN  
Tomorrow.

She stops, turns her body toward Gaitman. She reaches out, her fingers on Gaitman's sweater. Two strokes across the coarse wool at his chest.

LOLA  
Yes, tomorrow.

She mounts her bicycle and rides away, vanishing into the warm night.

22 INT. RAY'S ROOM - NIGHT

A hand grips the beam at the balcony doorframe.

Ray begins to pull himself up with one arm. Once. Blood floods his neck and face.

Twice. His right arm shakes violently. Pain in the left arm forces his mouth open, but no sound comes.

Three. A crack. The beam snaps. He crashes to the floor. The full weight lands on his left arm. A heavy thud.

The door bursts open with a kick.

Botir rushes in. He sees Ray writhing on the ground, blood spilling from the torn wound on his arm.

BOTIR  
Boss said, don't move.

23 INT. GAITMAN'S ROOM - NIGHT

Gaitman stands at the window, watching the house across the street.

Ray lies on the floor inside, dragging himself toward the bathroom like a wounded bear. He re-bandages his wound with a new elastic band and white gauze.

Botir makes a round of the room and leaves.

Gaitman sits down, his cup filled to the brim with black coffee. His fingers hover over two sugar packets, lingering a second.

He doesn't touch them.

CUT TO:

The computer screen flashes. A message box appears.

MESSAGE BOX

Updates.

Gaitman types at the keyboard.

MESSAGE BOX (CONT'D)

When's the job?

GAITMAN (TEXT)

On his way to Samarkand.

MESSAGE BOX

Good.

Gaitman shuts down the computer, then sits on the bed, bare-chested, leaning back into the dark and looking outside.

His right hand rests on his chest, slides over his stomach, then moves lower.

His iris catches the orange street light.

24 EXT. ISHCHAN TOWN/AKHMEDOVA CLINIC - DAY

Malika rides a dusty and worn Suzuki motorcycle on her way to her clinic.

She removes her helmet carefully, not to touch the bruise at her lip.

Inside, she sees a man sitting in the corner of the operating room. She does not stop. She walks to the triage desk.

MALIKA

How many patients today?

NURSE

That man came.

MALIKA

How many patients today?

CUT TO:

Ray wakes in his drowsiness. Malika enters the operating room, pulling on plastic gloves as she walks.

She drops forceps and scissors into a tray filled with alcohol and gauze.

RAY

I waited for you all day.

Malika says nothing. She bends, checks Ray's wound. The scarred vessel splits open again. She slips a thermometer into his mouth. Forty-one degrees.

RAY (CONT'D)

I've been waiting for you all day.

Malika bursts.

MALIKA

So what? You want to hit me again?

Ray freezes. He glimpses the bruise at her lip. A beat.

Malika rebinds his wound, begins preparing an antibiotic injection.

MALIKA (CONT'D)

You're in bad shape. You need a real hospital. Otherwise you'll die.

RAY

This is a real hospital.

MALIKA

This is a poor clinic.

Malika lowers her head, wipes Ray's right arm with antiseptic, searching for a vein still usable.

All the elbow crease is covered with a scatter of puncture marks.

RAY

I just need to leave here alive. To see her again.

MALIKA

Your wife?

RAY

She'll wait for me, in the jungle.  
She told me, it's hot there, and wet.

Malika drives the needle into his vein. His words stop.

25 INT. GAITMAN'S ROOM - DAY

Gaitman sits in the room, waiting.

A soft knock at the door. He opens it. Lola stands there, in a white dress.

She enters, wandering around the room. At the closet, a khaki canvas pouch rests in the corner.

Gaitman stares at her. She does not linger there. She moves to Gaitman, bending toward him.

LOLA

I came because you said you could help  
me apply to an Australian university,  
right?

GAITMAN

Yes.

She points at the computer lying on the table.

LOLA

We use this?

GAITMAN

No. We don't use this.

LOLA

Then, come to my father's shop. That  
way we can meet again.

Gaitman says nothing.

He watches Lola step closer. Her breath quickens, chest rising.

Gaitman stands.

GAITMAN

Yes, I'll go to your shop tonight.

26 INT. HOTEL PAMIR FIRE STAIRS - DAY

Gaitman and Lola walk down the fire escape.

Halfway down, Lola reaches out and takes Gaitman's hand. He does not pull away.

They reach the first floor, a small shadowed corner opening to the street. Outside, school girls walk in twos and threes.

Lola's bicycle waits across the road quietly.

Gaitman feels Lola lean against him, her warmth seeping through the thin cotton of her dress, burning his arm.

She lets go. Runs into the street, pushes her bicycle, greets her

classmates, and disappears down the street.

27

INT. AKHMEDOVA CLINIC - DUSK

Malika gathers the medical instruments, cleans the table, and prepares to leave. Ray rises to his feet.

RAY

I saw you have a motorcycle. Can it carry two?

MALIKA

No. But if you want it, I'll lend it to you.

RAY

I only have one arm.

28

EXT. ISHCHAN TOWN ROAD - DUST

At the clinic entrance, they stand before a small Suzuki motorcycle.

Malika hesitates, then sits in the driver's seat, fastening her helmet. Ray climbs onto the back.

MALIKA

Where do we go?

RAY

Just ride around. This place isn't big.

Malika nods, starts the engine.

The motorcycle moves through Ishchan street. The call to prayer rises from the mosque. Old men on the street turn together, walking toward it.

Vendors spread rugs beside their stalls and kneel, facing southwest.

Ray's eyes scan along the street. Malika's scarf whips in the wind, brushing his face.

He leans close, shouting against the wind noise.

RAY (CONT'D)

Go home. You can go home now.

Malika nods, steering into another street. She pulls over at the crossroads of a commune.

Ray steps down from the back seat. She watches him limp toward the corner, into the sunset light.

Her husband appears and steps toward her, noticing the man in the distance.

MALIKA

My patient.

29

INT. ARZON KITOBLAR BOOKSTORE - DUST

Ray holds still at the entrance of a secondhand bookstore called Arzon Kitoblar. It's the place he passed earlier on the motorcycle.

He looks around. Botir does not appear. He steps in.

Bookshelves are filled with old volumes—cheap novels and gardening manuals. On the tables lie Russian editions of assorted used books.

Ray searches among them for travel guides. There are some battered Lonely Planet.

He picks up a Southeast Asia guide. He opens the section of Thailand.

He stands motionless, staring at the map, which is crowded with notes scrawled by former owner, and the photos: temples, jungle, the Mekong River.

A voice calls out.

SOBIROV

Tourist?

Ray looks up. Before him stands an MVD officer, close to fifty, clean-shaven, temples gray, tall in stature.

His indigo uniform bears two stars, a lieutenant. Lieutenant Sobirov.

RAY

Yes. Tourist.

SOBIROV

Passport.

Ray remains silent. His eyes study Sobirov's face, saying nothing.

SOBIROV (CONT'D)  
Show me your passport.

Ray's body freezes.

Sobirov stares at his empty left sleeve, then lets his gaze fall to the pair of military boots.

SOBIROV (CONT'D)  
You were soldier?

RAY  
Yes. Airborne. Retired.

SOBIROV  
My younger brother too. He was in Ferghana Valley. Ninety-nine. He didn't come back.

He picks up the tattered Lonely Planet from Ray's right hand, glances at it, then hands it back.

SOBIROV (CONT'D)  
Don't stay longer if you have no white paper.

He turns, walks out of the bookstore, and drives away in the Chevrolet Nexia parked at the door.

30 EXT. ISHCHAN TOWN - DAY

Ray walks along the street, collar turned up, wrapped in a local wool coat hiding his missing left arm.

A Toyota Tundra follows a hundred meters behind, moving like a ghost. Gaitman watches him.

Ray keeps scanning as he walks. He stops at the entrance of a repair shop. Inside are cars waiting for service. Beside it stands a used Ford Mondeo for sale. 1500 US dollars.

RAY  
Is this car for sale?

The mechanic shakes his head, speaking broken English.

MECHANIC  
Not to foreigners.

Ray steps back out, then he enters again.

RAY  
I rent it. 1000 one day.

The mechanic shakes his head blankly, repeating once more.

MECHANIC  
No, no foreigner.

Ray stands there, studying the sagging garage door, the rusted lock, and a row of colored keys hanging on a wooden rack along the wall.

In the distance, Gaitman sits in his truck, watching in silence.  
He starts the engine while Ray steps back to the street.

31 EXT. OLD HAJJI HOTEL - DAY

Ray walks to the front of the Old Hajji hotel. He stands by the street. Suddenly, he looks toward Gaitman.

Gaitman sits in his Tundra, unmoving. He's certain Ray doesn't know him.

They seem to lock eyes.

But Gaitman realizes Ray is looking at someone else. Gaitman turns his head.

Botir sits on a chair by the street, lips pressed, staring at Ray.

Ray walks toward Botir.

RAY  
I want my thing tomorrow.

BOTIR  
Boss working.

RAY  
Tomorrow.

Ray finishes and enters the hotel.

Gaitman remains still in the car. His right hand rests below the driver's seat, resting on his Glock 17.

Botir watches Ray's back, turns away.

32 INT. MAA & SONS CAFÉ - NIGHT

Lola still sits there, staring at Gaitman's empty seat from yesterday.

Beside her, a prepared drink rests on the table.

A voice comes.

RAY

A payphone.

LOLA

No international. 15000 som.

Lola points with her finger. Ray looks at her, says nothing, taking a payphone card from Lola and walks straight to the

payphone.

He dials.

33 INT. AMIR'S CLINIC - DUSK

Dr. Amir steps outside. His family prepares for a trip. The children are noisy, restless.

A taxi waits at the curb, its trunk packed with luggage. The loading is finished. They are about to get in while the phone rings inside the clinic.

Amir ignores it.

AMIR (TO DRIVER)

Let's go. I'm off duty.

The driver starts the engine. The car pulls away.

Amir sits in the front seat, the children noisy in the back.

Across the noise, the phone keeps ringing, faint and distant.

34 INT. MAA & SONS CAFÉ - NIGHT

Ray holds the phone, the line filled with endless waiting. He keeps it raised, never setting it down.

In the distance, Lola sits on a chair, her eyes fixed on the cloudy sky far away.

Ray stands to the left of the payphone. On his right, a tall freezer.

Behind it, a man—Gaitman.

Ray is about to hang up the receiver when a voice comes through.

AMIR  
Amir's clinic.

RAY  
Doctor.

AMIR  
Who is it?

RAY  
I need you to prepare a car. The morning after tomorrow. I repeat: the morning of the day after tomorrow, meet me in Ishchan, at the place where I got off. Do you remember? You must come.

On the line, Amir says nothing.

AMIR  
Sir...

Gaitman disappears at the back of the freezer.

He observes Lola in the distance, and turns away.

Lola stares blankly.

Her father approaches, taps her back with the handle of a spatula.

FATHER (UZBEK)  
Alisher keladi. U faqat bir kecha qoladi.  
(Alisher comes. He stays only one night.)

Lola turns.

Outside the shop, a young man in his twenties speaks with her brother.

Her brother takes a gift box from his hands.

Alisher wears a mandarin collar, a black briefcase in his right hand. Slightly heavyset, handsome.

He sees Lola approaching, smiles again, waves.

Suddenly, a phone rings at his waist.

Lola watches as he turns away, walks several meters to answer the

call, bowing unconsciously as he speaks.

He turns back, gives Lola a distant greeting.

35

EXT. ISHCHAN TOWN - NIGHT

The street is not quiet. Food from the night market fills the air with fragrance. Shashlik sizzles on the charcoal, sprinkled with onions. Horse-meat sausages simmer in a pot of vegetables and spices, greasy foam rising.

Gaitman walks down the middle of the street, frowning.

He takes a deep breath, sidestepping as a housewife throws a pan of slop onto the pavement.

He collides with a boy, who wears a sheepskin cap, thin and frail.

Gaitman does not help him up. He only watches as the boy rises, dusts himself off, picks up the papers that fell and walks on.

Gaitman reaches the next intersection and turns right, heading toward the Pamir hotel.

This street is nearly deserted. He sees the same boy from before, standing at the roadside, vacant eyes fixed on the sky.

Gaitman passes him without stopping.

BOY

Sir...

Gaitman ignores him, keeps walking.

The boy reaches out, trying to grab Gaitman's coat. Suddenly, he feels his body lift, the world flipping upside down and the ground rushes toward his face.

He crashes hard onto the pavement, screaming once. Then his body lifts again. He sees Gaitman holding him, looking at him.

BOY (CONT'D)

Sir...do you want this?

The boy, trembling, hands Gaitman a small slip of paper. It's a handful of garish print, crude image of a plump naked woman, with a phone and an email address.

Gaitman releases the boy, holding the paper. The boy looks at him,

realizes the man says nothing.

He chooses to leave, runs, vanishing into the dark night.

36 INT. GAITMAN'S ROOM - NIGHT

The house is pitch dark, curtains are drawn tight.

Gaitman sits in a chair, same place as before. He listens to the sound outside.

From the wooden hallway comes the sound of footsteps—high heels striking the floor.

His throat moves; he swallows. On the table before him, three empty coffee cups. Behind him, the door stands ajar.

The foot steps stops, a gentle knock. Gaitman does not answer. The door begins to push open, inch by inch.

The light snaps on. Gaitman rises at once, turning. In the light he sees a woman at the doorway, holding a bag, dressed in an old pale- violet silk dress with a round collar.

Gaitman's eyes have not yet reached her face.

GAITMAN  
Turn off the light.

The light goes out.

Only then does his gaze move upward. A woman's face, about forty. Heavy eye shadow. A wide mouth. A beautiful nose. Her neckline plunges low, her breasts firm.

WOMAN  
May I sit down? My feet hurt.

GAITMAN  
Yes.

CUT TO:

Gaitman seizes the woman, forcing her against the wall, lifting her feet off the ground.

She clings to him, breathless, struggling under the weight of his presence.

She could feel that Gaitman's back was covered in sweat.

WOMAN

Slower.

But Gaitman does not relent.

He throws her onto the bed, then lifts her legs from behind and turns her upside down.

Woman's hand reaches for the bag on the floor. Her movements keep her from grasping anything.

Then, everything stops.

Gaitman's eyes fix on something beyond her. She turns.

At the doorway, faintly yellow light from the corridor spills in.

A young girl stands there, wearing a wool cardigan.

The woman rises from the bedside, pulls the white sheet over Gaitman's body. She picks up the bag from the floor, walks toward the bathroom, begins to wash.

Lola stands at the doorway, eyes lowered.

Only the sound of water comes from the bathroom.

The water stops. Woman emerges, dressed again.

WOMAN (CONT'D)

One hundred U.S. dollars.

GAITMAN

Money is on the desk.

She moves to the table to take the money. By then, Lola has vanished.

Woman walks to the door, closing it softly. The room falls back into darkness.

Gaitman rises from the bed, dresses. He pulls the curtain slightly open.

Outside, a light rain falls.

37

INT. RAY'S ROOM - NIGHT

Ray lies in bed, eyes open, sleepless.

Outside the door, voices—muddled, indistinct. Slowly, the noise fades into silence.

He rises, pulls his SOG from beneath the mattress, slides it into his boot.

He opens the door quietly. The hallway is empty. He descends the stairs.

In the inn's lobby, the stove burns with fire. On the table, a cup of tea still steams.

But no one is there.

The passage to the backyard opens into a small courtyard. Rain falls from the sky.

Under the column, a man lies face-down, motionless. Blood seeps from beneath his left rib, soaking his clothes, running with the rainwater into the center of the yard.

Ray draws his SOG, walks forward slowly. He nudges the body with his foot, turning it over.

Botir, dead.

In his right hand, a long dagger. Another wound marks his stomach.

Ray bends down, places his hand beneath Botir's nose. Cold.

Ray sets down his SOG, picks up the fallen dagger, weighs it. Not right. He thrust it into the woodpile, retrieves his own.

In the corner of the yard, an attic. A wooden staircase hidden in shadow. Old Hajji's wool vest lies at the bottom of the steps.

Blood trails upward along the steps.

Ray's heart pounds violently.

38

INT. OLD HAJJI'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Ray steps heavily into the room. By the stove, Old Hajji lies on the floor, wearing only a cotton undershirt.

A terrible wound runs from the back of his neck down toward his waist, deep as a canyon.

He crawls weakly, inching toward his cold, empty stove.

Ray crouches beside him, lifting his head.

RAY

Where is my passport.

Old Hajji looks at him, murmuring through blood-tinged foam.

OLD HAJJI  
Money...money...

Ray lets go of his head. It drops hard to the floor. He searches Old Hajji's body quickly—nothing.

He rises, rummages through the room—nothing.

Returning, he seizes Old Hajji's chest.

RAY  
My passport! Speak!

OLD HAJJI  
My money...give me...

Ray places his finger in the massive knife wound on Old Hajji's back, stirring it. The immense pain causes his body to curl up like a lobster.

RAY  
Where is it?

OLD HAJJI  
Emm...

His voice weakens, his face pales, his eyes dim, gradually lose their light.

Ray unbuttons his coat, wraps it around Old Hajji with one hand.

RAY  
Hey! Hold on!

But the body grows cold. His last word.

OLD HAJJI  
Money...

Ray lays him flat, pounds his chest—no response. He slaps Old Hajji's face—nothing.

Ray feels a chill at his neck. A Damascus blade, wet with cold rain, presses against his throat.

Ray turns. Two figures stand behind him. One is Aziz, holding a brown paper bag, half-soaked with rainwater.

A massive shadow strikes the back of Ray's head. Darkness.

39

INT. GAITMAN'S ROOM - NIGHT

Gaitman opens the closet door, reaching inside. His hand touches the cold rifle.

He takes out the Glock 17, resting it in his palm.

The coffee machine brews black coffee, a dark stream pouring into a paper cup.

Gaitman's movement halts. All quiet, only the final three seconds of the machine's noise remain.

He puts the rifle back, tucks the Glock 17 at his waist. He strides to the doorway, flings the door open.

A strong current of air lifts the girl's dress at the threshold.

Lola stands at the door, wearing a dress, barefoot. Her hair is wet. Rain stains the shoulders of her dress. The cold wind in the hallway makes her shiver.

Gaitman looks at her. After a few seconds, he raises his hand, lifting her chin, her lowered face.

Lola wears makeup—eye shadow, a faint gloss on her lips.

Gaitman smiles, faintly. He slowly lays the frail Lola gently on the bed, resting his head against her soft waist.

Lola closes her eyes.

CUT TO:

Gaitman exhales deeply, weary, turning his body over, sitting up.

On the table, a pack of cigarettes, but no lighter. He takes one cigarette, holding it in his hand.

Lola rises quietly, wiping herself.

She dresses, sitting on the edge of the bed. Her back to Gaitman.

LOLA

When will you take me away?

Gaitman tears open the cigarette paper, crumbling it between his fingers, letting the tobacco fall through the air, scattering onto the carpet.

LOLA (CONT'D)

If you plan to run, betray me, I will  
tell my father you raped me.

Gaitman rises, walks to the window. He senses movement behind him. Lola slips out barefoot, noiseless.

Gaitman pulls open the curtain. Daylight already appears at the horizon, a white band pressed down by heavy black clouds.

He looks at Ray's window across the street.

The curtain flutters, inside is empty.

40

EXT. RIVER SHORE - DAWN

Ray feels his body dragged across the sand. He slowly regains consciousness, the sky receding above him.

His hand and feet are bound, a filthy cloth stuffed in his mouth.

Two men pull at his right arm, dragging him across the damp ground.

To the right side, a small river. At dawn, white mist gathers over the surface of the water.

Aziz walks with a younger boy, no more than thirteen or fourteen. The boy carries a shovel on his left shoulder. They drag Ray to the riverbank and begin digging.

Ray, tightly bound, cannot move. He watches as the pit grows deeper. When the hole is ready, they lift him—one by the legs, one by the shoulder—and throw him in.

Ray thrashes violently, futile against his fate.

Cold river water seeps into the pit. Half-kneeling, he tries to rise. The boy swings the shovel, smashing Ray's left arm.

Pain drops him. The boy, more brutal than Aziz, jumps in, striking again and again.

AZIZ (UZBEK)

Rustam, to'xta!  
(Rustam, stop!)

Aziz climbs down, holding a rain-soaked brown paper bag before Ray's

eyes. He tears it open, pulls out a passport, sets it before him.

AZIZ (CONT'D)

My father work for you. You kill my  
father. You, murderer.

He slaps Ray hard, then pries open Ray's mouth with his muddy  
hand, shoves the passport inside, forces it shut.

AZIZ (CONT'D)

Take you want.

They climb out, shoveling dirt back into the pit. Soil rains  
down, rising around Ray. Darkness begins to swallow his head.

At the edge, Aziz and the boy, Rustam, stand.

RUSTAM (UZBEK)

Amakivachcha, u shunday o'lib  
ketadimi?  
(Cousin, will he die like this?)

AZIZ (UZBEK)

Ha, o'ladi.  
(He will.)

RUSTAM (UZBEK)

Bilmayman... agar biz ketganimizdan  
keyin u o'zi chiqib ketsa-chi?  
(I don't know...what if he crawls  
out after we leave?)

Aziz says nothing. The boy digs again, uncovering Ray's head.  
The boy crouches, hand at Ray's nose.

RUSTAM (UZBEK) (CONT'D)

U hali tirik.  
(He's still alive.)

He rises, swings the shovel down heavily toward Ray's skull.

A sharp gunshot cracks.

The boy's neck is pierced, he collapses.

Aziz turns instinctively, searching for the source. A second  
shot.

Aziz falls, struck in the left eye, beside Ray.

On the far bank, Gaitman stands, rifle in hand.

CUT TO:

Gaitman comes to Ray's side. He digs the soil from Ray's neck,  
clearing space for him breathe.

He crouches, pulls the passport from Ray's mouth. He opens it: a finely crafted Thailand passport.

There is a photo, codes, several well-forged entry stamps. The name is written in unfamiliar East Asian characters he doesn't care.

He feels Ray's pulse at the neck. Still alive.

He pushes the passport back into Ray's mouth. Two seconds later, he takes it out again, slips it into Ray's jacket pocket, and cleans the dirt from his mouth.

He shovels away the soil around Ray, exposing his upper body.

He pulls Ray out of the pit. He lifts him, holding him against his chest, wading across the shallow river, he carries Ray. On the opposite bank, he lays Ray flat on the ground.

Then he returns alone to the riverbank he came from. He begins digging Ray's pit, enlarging it.

He lifts the bodies of Aziz and Rustam, drops them into the pit.

He takes the shovel, throws it into the river.

On the sand, he searches, finds two bullets, tosses them into the water.

Afterward, he walks into the bushes, finds a place to lie down. He feels exhausted. He has not slept all night.

CUT TO BLACK.

Gaitman wakes, his face burning under the harsh sun. He opens his eyes, sits up.

The sunlight blazes all around, quiet, only the river flows. He checks his watch. One o'clock.

Across the riverbank, empty. Ray is gone.

He puts the rifle into the khaki canvas pouch, jogs along the river.

He reaches his Tundra. From his jacket pocket, he takes out a monocular scope. Climbing onto the roof of the car, he scans from the riverbank toward the town.

In the distance, he sees Ray—limping, moving slowly. Each step is heavy. His head bowed, like a wounded lone wolf.

Gaitman jumps down from the roof, gets into the truck. He starts the

engine.

41 I/E. HOTEL PAMIR - GAITMAN'S ROOM - DAY

Gaitman stops the car, returns to the fire escape stairs of the Pamir Hotel.

He enters through the doorway, strides upstairs, and into his room.

Inside, a cleaner girl is at work. Gaitman waves her out. He locks the door, places the rifle back in its place.

He switches on the coffee machine. The computer flashes a pop-up.

MESSAGE BOX

Updates?

GAITMAN (TEXT)

Tomorrow morning.

He drinks the coffee in a single gulp.

He sits, checking his watch.

Minutes pass. He rises, steps out the door.

42 EXT. OLD HAJJI HOTEL - DAY

Three police cars stand at the hotel entrance. MVD officers move in and out, securing the scene.

Gaitman watches from behind the crowd, eyes fixed on the surroundings. Ray approaches from afar.

Among the police, Ray sees Lieutenant Sobirov. He turns at once, slipping away, vanishing quietly around the corner behind the crowd.

Gaitman also steps back. At that moment, a MVD officer arrives holding a plastic bag. Inside, a large envelope.

He hands it to Sobirov—ten thousand dollars in cash. Sobirov studies

the face of the officer opposite him, then returns the envelope.

The officer smiles, turns, and walks away.

43 INT. AKHMEDOVA CLINIC - DUSK

The nurse tidies her workstation. She notices a shadow standing before her. She looks up.

Malika is in the washroom, washing her hands, covered in blood and purple antiseptic.

The nurse approaches.

NURSE That man is here. Waiting in the operating room.

MALIKA

Is he?

NURSE

He seems...worse.

Malika nods, dries her hands quickly, and leaves.

She reaches the operating room door. Head lowered, she pauses for a second, then opens it.

Inside, the room is empty. No one.

A set of syringes, antibiotics, and adrenaline is missing from the

corner cabinet. On the top, blood-stained U.S. dollar bills lie scattered.

44 INT. CHORSU HAMMAM - NIGHT

An old public bathhouse at the corner of the street. Dim lights.

The doorman sits before a small LCD TV, watching a soap TV series. At the entrance, a sign reads: Shower - 2000 som, Bath - 5000 som.

He sees a man approach, handing him a five-dollar U.S. bill.

The man's left arm is missing, his sleeve stained with blood and mud. In his right hand, a plastic bag.

The doorman shakes his head, points at the missing arm.

DOORMAN

No.

Ray searches his pockets. Only two ten-dollar bills remain. He notices the change in the doorman's eye.

He takes one bill, hands it over.

CUT TO:

Deep inside, the bathroom is crowded with vague figures. Steam thickens the air, the yellow tungsten light reaching only a few meters ahead. Ray settles in a dark corner.

He injects three doses of antibiotics and adrenaline into his body. Eyes closed, he waits, then opens them again.

From his pocket, he takes out the finely made fake Thailand passport. Soil, faint watermarks, traces of blood stain its cover.

He studies it carefully, then puts it back into his pocket. He signals to a boy standing against the wall, a young masseur.

The boy comes closer. Ray hands him his last ten-dollar bill.

BOY MASSEUR

Massage, free. No money.

Ray keeps holding the money, not lowering his hand. A smile lingers on his face.

The smile unsettles the boy—he steps back, almost stumbling. Ray notices, nods slightly.

RAY

Food. Buy me something to eat.

The boy masseur nods, takes the money.

RAY (CONT'D)

Wait. When you come back, look around.  
See if anyone, any strange person,  
looking here, looking you. You tell  
me. Ok?

The boy tries to understand what Ray said.

RAY (CONT'D)

You can keep the change...

The boy nods again and leaves.

Ray exhales deeply, leaning against the wall, fighting the weight of exhaustion.

The boy returns, holding a heap of food. Coins spill in his hand.

Ray takes the food, watching him.

BOY MASSEUR

No man look me. No man look us. Sir.

RAY

Thank you.

The boy masseur hesitates, then slips the change into the towel he carries.

Ray lowers his head, begins to eat. The food is greasy, almost makes him retch, but he forces himself to chew, bite by bite, wasting nothing.

When he finishes, he lies down on the wet floor, drifting into sleep.

Twenty minutes pass. He wakes, gathers the remaining syringes and vials, places them in a plastic bag, then into his pocket.

With effort, he props himself on the ground, struggling to rise. He walks deeper into the bathhouse, toward the back.

He pushes open the rear door. A chill wind rushes in. Night has fallen.

Ahead lies a drainage channel, sixty or seventy meters long, cutting through the yard, leading into a dark, sinister watercourse.

Ray scans the tall buildings around him, shadows everywhere.

He draws a long breath, crawls into the channel. In the filthy water, he inches forward. Beyond, weeds and shrubs.

Through them, the outlines of city buildings. Beside them, a mosque's minaret

rises into the night sky, towering above.

45

I/E. ISHCHAN BAZAAR - NIGHT

Gaitman walks through the largest bazaar in Ishchan. He carries a few children's toys in his hand.

He keeps looking around. He pauses at a fur stall. The vendor watches him eagerly.

VENDOR

A lady's fur coat, twenty dollars!  
Real goods!

Gaitman looks, says nothing. He walks on. After a few steps, he slows, then turns back.

He picks up a woman's fur coat, carrying it as he walks. A few steps later, he sees a car quietly parked by an electronics stall.

A new Ford Mondeo.

Two men are unloading the goods from the trunk.

Gaitman begins to run, full speed, all his strength.

The crowd freezes, startled, not knowing why.

As he runs, he drops everything—the fur coat, the children's toys.

He bursts out of the bazaar, sprinting deep into the street.

46 EXT. REPAIR SHOP - NIGHT

He reaches the repair shop. Chaos. The iron gate stands open. The mechanic lies on the ground, a SOG blade buried in his stomach.

The wooden rack on the wall has collapsed. Keys scatter across the floor, bright colors everywhere.

That secondhand Ford Mondeo is gone.

Heavy tire marks scar the ground. A fire hydrant lies shattered, water gushing out.

Gaitman pulls his Glock 17 from his waist and sprints down the street.

47 EXT. ISHCHAN TOWN - NIGHT

Gaitman pulls his Glock 17 from his waist, sprinting down the street.

Ahead, a Ford Mondeo speeds forward, its path erratic, swerving.

Gaitman shifts direction, dives into an alley, vaults over low walls, racing across rooftops.

In his sightline, Ray's Mondeo lurches through narrow lanes, aiming for the next intersection.

Gaitman leaps down, lands at the crossroads. He raises his arm, fires at the car charging toward him.

The headlights flare, blinding white.

Ray sees nothing. The windshield shatters under the first two bullets.

Through the broken glass, he glimpses a figure a hundred meters ahead.

Another round tears into the right side of his chest. Ray slams the accelerator, driving straight at the shooter.

Gaitman stands firm.

Seventeen rounds pour from the Glock, ripping through windshield and hood. The car's front crumples under fire. The magazine empties, yet the vehicle maintains its speed.

Gaitman presses the release, pulls a spare magazine from his pocket, reloads single-handed. The slide snaps back, chamber ready.

Suddenly, the car veers left—ninety degrees. It smashes through a steel awning support, the right headlight crushed. Dragging a sheet of torn plastic, it staggers into a side street to Gaitman's right.

Gaitman turns, running back.

He swings his arms, driving himself full force toward the Pamir Hotel.

48 I/E. HOTEL PAMIR - NIGHT

Gaitman bursts into his room, throws open the closet.

The rifle is gone.

He stands there for a second. The khaki canvas pouch on the floor is

missing too.

He rushes out of the room.

49 I/E. HOTEL PAMIR - NIGHT

Gaitman rushes into the kitchen. Azamat is there, the cleaning girl beside him. They both startle at Gaitman's sudden entrance.

Gaitman charges toward Azamat. Just as he is about to reach him, the back door opens.

Sobirov enters, holding Gaitman's rifle and his khaki canvas pouch. He sees Gaitman. Only five meters between them.

Gaitman draws his Glock 17 and fires. At the same time, Sobirov raises the rifle, swinging the stock hard.

Gaitman ducks instinctively. The stock smashes into the cement wall, plaster breaking loose.

Gaitman lowers his head, grabs the off-balance Sobirov. The Glock barrel presses against his chest. Five shots. The sound is muffled.

Sobirov drops like a sack to the floor.

Gaitman turns, Azamat stands frozen there. A bullet tears through his right cheek.

Gaitman picks up the fallen rifle. The barrel and receiver are broken. He throws it aside.

On the floor, the cleaning girl trembles, shaking violently. Gaitman strides toward her. From the chopping board behind her, he throws the empty Glock 17 and seizes a large butcher's knife.

He raises the blade, storms out of the kitchen.

50

EXT. YARD - NIGHT

Bloodied, knife in hand, Gaitman runs toward his Toyota Tundra. The truck waits in the hotel courtyard, parked in the corner.

The courtyard is empty.

Gaitman leaps into his truck, throws the butcher's knife onto the passenger seat.

He starts the engine, shifts into first, releases the clutch, slams the accelerator.

The vehicle shudders, lurches forward a meter, then stalls.

He jumps out. All four tires are slashed, flat to the ground. He yanks the door open, grabs the knife, and runs across the yard toward the gate.

Suddenly, pain strikes his leg. He crashes to the ground. A sharpened wooden stake thrusts from a direction, then others, from every direction, piercing his calf and other parts of the body.

He feels no pain, rises, and keeps running.

Stones rain down, striking his head, his chest. Around him is a crowd. Hundreds of men he doesn't know, torches in hand, encircle him.

They curse, spit, hurl stones, beat him with iron rods. Gaitman raises his butcher's knife. A spike drives through his palm. He still wants to swing his knife—an axe cleaves his right hand away.

Bloodied, broken, his vision darkens.

Through the blur, his Tundra still stands in the center of the yard. He crawls toward it, his final refuge, inch by inch.

The attacks stop. The men watch him drag himself back to the truck.

He staggers upright, swaying. With the last of his strength, he opens the door.

He sits inside, staring out. The windows shatter under the iron rods.

Molotovs crash in, flaming torches follow.

In the firelight, he sees women behind the men. He sees Lola's mother. He sees Lola's father. He seeks Lola's brother.

49      And a girl in a heavy black robe, face veiled by a niqab, only her eyes visible.

It is Lola.

51      EXT. ISHCHAN OUTSKIRTS - NIGHT

On the barren steppe outside Ishchan, Ray sits in his car.

The vehicle slows, the shattered windows and broken engine coughs white smoke. Finally, the engine dies.

Ray steps out, looks around. He walks along the road, directionless, moving only away from Ishchan.

Behind him, the town center burns, flames rising into the green-tinged sky.

His pace falters. An hour later, He sees the horizon pale—a thin white line of dawn.

A car approaches from the opposite side, passes him, then brakes. It reverses, stopping beside him. A man leans out.

                         AMIR  
                         Sir Iskandarov?

Ray looks at him, then collapses, strength gone.

52 INT. CAR - NIGHT

Amir is driving.

AMIR

We'll get you to a hospital.

RAY

No. Samarkand Airport. Now.

Ray lies in the back seat. The bullet has pierced the Lonely Planet guide he kept in his right chest pocket.

Blood soaks through the book.

Outside, the sky grows brighter. Ray's eyes darken.

53 EXT. JUNGLE - DAY

The river surface glimmers under the bright sun. Midday steam rises from the water. Dense tropical rainforest surrounds the banks.

A boat pushes upstream through the murky yellow current.

In the distance, beneath a towering kapok tree, A vague shadow of a

woman stands, waiting, watching for the boat's arrival.

54 INT. AKHMEDOVA CLINIC - DUSK

Malika arrives at the hospital, removes her helmet, and steps inside. The corridors are crowded, bustling as always.

She walks to the nurse's station.

MALIKA

How many patients today?

NURSE

Around fifty.

MALIKA

All right.

She continues down the hall.

At the operating room door, she glances inside almost unconsciously.

The room is still empty.

55 INT. GAITMAN'S ROOM - DAY

On the desk, the computer screen. Empty room. Curtains flutter.

A message window pops up:

MESSAGE BOX

Updates?

One minute later, the window flashes again:

MESSAGE BOX (CONT'D)

Updates?

On the computer screen, after ten seconds of silence, a Command Line Interface displays:

"SAMARKAND FILE IS BEING DELETED."

**END OF SCRIPT**